

03 COSTA MUERTA

ADVENTURE 3: COSTA MUERTA

BACKGROUND

Two weeks since the clinic siege. The droneware is out, the players are healing, Arasaka is consuming itself in an internal investigation that's spilling into the financial press. Lazard is still alive but increasingly cornered — Kojo's network reports he's been pulled from active duty, his accounts frozen pending audit. He is no longer pointing kill teams at the players. He is fighting to stay out of a corporate confessional booth.

The party still has two sealed droneware units. Sitting on them in Night City is a slow-motion mistake — every fixer in the city is starting to ask the wrong questions, and Trauma Team has been polite-but-curious about a depot job from the same week. **It's time to cash out and disappear for a stretch.**

Kojo has the lead. He's been quietly putting out the word south of the border, where the post-Corp-War legal vacuum means a sealed Arasaka R&D black box is a *trophy*, not a *risk*. Buyers have surfaced. The big one happens once a month: **Costa Muerta**, the offshore black-market biotech auction held on the Pacific rig city of **Nueva Costa**. Three days of credibility tour in Tijuana to land a sponsor, then helicopter to the rigs for auction night.

Departure window: now. The next Costa Muerta is in seven days, and the lunar timing won't repeat for a month.

Core tension: This isn't a chase any more. The players are sellers, not prey. They have leverage, they have time, they have a road south — and they have two unmarked devices in a cooler that the most dangerous corporation on Earth would set the continent on fire to recover. The pressure now is *what they choose to do with that power*, and which faction they want carrying their card after this is done.

MAJOR NPCS

NPC	ROLE	DETAILS
Kojo Asante	Fredrik's fixer (recurring)	Brokered the southern route. Wants a piece for the introduction. Genuinely invested in the team now — they made him look good
Mateo Cruz	Aldecaldos waystation elder	Nomad warrior-priest type. Old, scarred, weighs people fast. Holds the keys to safe passage south of the Free Fire Zone
Don Bicho “El Cien Patas”	Raider warlord	Cybered-up highway predator running a convoy crew of ex-Arasaka security gone freelance. Hits anyone who can't afford the Aldecaldos toll
Comandante Castillo	Feudal border-checkpoint warlord	Ex-Federal officer who absorbed an abandoned border facility and runs it like a fiefdom. Reasonable if paid, brutal if not
Ofelia “Ofi” Castañeda	Kojo's Tijuana fixer	Runs the players' TJ safehouse and a flower-shop front in Zona Norte. Sharp, fast, doesn't sleep. Knows everybody who matters
Doña Esperanza Vargas	Los Curanderos matriarch	Ripperdoc syndicate boss. Older woman, missionary-cool, runs her empire from a former cathedral. Genuinely religious in a dark way
Reyna Solano “La Viuda”	Cyber-lucha star	Top of the Tuesday card. Sandevistan + monomolecular fan blade. Famous, broke, looking for a way out of the circuit
El Padre / El Hijo del Diablo	Cyber-lucha tag opponents	Reyna's tag partners. El Padre is a slam-grappler full-borg, El Hijo is a fire-breathing showman
Mr. Carlos Vega	Militech cutout	Smooth, ex-Special Forces, real name probably not Vega. Approaches the players after the lucha bout. Knows their NC file in unsettling detail
Tía Esmé Aldecaldo	Aldecaldos auction rep	Senior member of the actual Aldecaldo family. Wants droneware as a counter-corp deterrent for the Nomad nation. Pays in alliance more than cash
Iku Tanaka	“Independent” buyer (the trap)	Claims to represent a Pacific Rim medical conglomerate. Polite, precise, slightly off. Actually Arasaka counterintelligence under deep cover
The Mole	Recurring from Adv 1–2	Brief background sighting on the road north. No interaction this session. Confirms they got out

CALENDAR

The auction is fixed. The journey is paced backwards from auction night.

DAY	EVENT
D-8	The Send-Off. Kitting up in Night City (cyberware, weapons, vehicles).
D-7	Kojo's final brief at Suki's. Convoy departs Night City at dusk.
D-6	Free Fire Zone. Don Bicho's highway ambush.
D-5	Aldecaldos waystation. Raider counter-attack.
D-4	Border crossing (La Frontera). Brief glimpse of the Mole heading north.
D-3	Arrive Tijuana. Ofelia's safehouse. Buyer landscape briefing.
D-2	La Lucha Cromada (cyber-lucha bout).
D-1	Buyer tour (Curanderos, Militech, Aldecaldos, Tanaka). Robbery attempt on safehouse.
D-0	Helicopter transit to Nueva Costa. Costa Muerta auction.

GM Note: Don't run the calendar as a literal pressure clock. Use it as a structural skeleton. The auction date is the only hard deadline — if the players want to spend two sessions on the credibility tour because they're loving it, let them. The schedule above is "if they keep moving."

ADVENTURE STRUCTURE

Part 0: The Send-Off (Night City)

Two weeks of downtime have given the team time to heal, sit on the droneware, and — crucially — *spend money*. Past adventures have been frugal; the team is thin on chrome. With a 100k+ eb sale on the horizon, Kojo's 15k brokerage already on the table, and a credible road ahead, this is the moment to fix that.

GM Note: This is essentially a structured shopping montage with three stops. Aim for 30-45 minutes of play. The point is to let players pick their loadout, get a return-visit beat with Voss, and arrive at the highway *kitted*. Don't make it a fetch quest — there's no obstacles or rolls here unless the players insert their own drama. Run it like a montage with a few dialogue beats.

Stop 1: Dr. Voss's Clinic — Cyberware Install

Tanaka's Fish Market, same back-room clinic from Adventure 2. The smell is exactly as bad as remembered. Udo is reading a different paperback now (a Russian historical fiction, dog-eared). Voss has changed nothing about the operating room — the same hardened blast door, the same shelving of components, the same near-pristine surgical theater that exists in the worst-smelling building in Night City.

She greets them politely. They are *even* — she does not owe them, they do not owe her. This is cash business now. But the warmth is real.

"You came back. Good. I have a new espresso machine."

She charges fair market rate. Standard install times are abbreviated for the team — Voss is fast, and she has favorable opinions of their nervous systems by now. Surgical downtime: 24-48 hours, which they spend recovering on the road during Day 1 of travel. Mats can sleep in the cargo van; Fredrik and Digitz can drive in shifts.

Suggested cyberware packages (each PC picks ~10-15k eb of upgrades; flexible):

For Mats (Solo — survivability + lucha + ranged): - **Subdermal Armor** (1,000 eb, +SP under clothes — stacks with armor) - **Big Knux** (100 eb, 2d6 brawling damage — *built for the lucha bout*) - **Pain Editor** (1,000 eb — ignore Seriously Wounded penalties; he was a near-death revive last session and this is the obvious answer) - **Smartgun Link** (1,000 eb — works with his Assault Rifle and SMG) - **Cybereye TeleOptics** (1,000 eb — extends ranged engagement range) - Optional: **Kerenzikov** (1,000 eb, +2 init) — if he wants more action economy

For Fredrik (Fixer — social armor + survivability + driving): - **Skinweave** (500 eb premium, +SP everywhere) - **Tactile Boost** (500 eb — useful in negotiations and driving) - **Armorjack Businesswear** (2,000 eb — premium SP 13 armored suit, looks like a tailored jacket) - **Personal AI Driver Interface** (2,000 eb — for the second vehicle; lets the car semi-autonomously evade while he focuses on shooting/talking) - **Cyberdeck (basic)** (1,000 eb — entry-level backup hacking; he's not Digitz but having his own deck for low-stakes work is operator-grade)

For Digitz (Netrunner — netpower + emergency survival): - **Cybermodem upgrade** (5,000 eb — top-shelf, +1 to Interface checks effectively) - **Extra Interface Plugs** (200 eb — second port set) - **Sandevistan** (1,000 eb — emergency speedware; netrunners go down fast in physical combat, this is the escape switch) - **Two new combat/utility programs** (~1,000 eb total — pick from the program list: Armor / Sword / Hellhound / DeckKRASH / Eraser) - Optional: **Subdermal Pocket** (500 eb — concealable storage for a spare deck or weapon)

Voss's parting note (Pain Editor warning to Mats only): *"This will let you keep fighting through wounds your body is telling you not to. Listen to your body anyway. The cyberware tells you 'fine.' It does not actually fix anything."* Genuine medical advice. Worth remembering at the table.

Stop 2: Kojo's Yard — Wheels

A walled compound behind a strip mall in Watson. Kojo runs a side business in clean vehicles — mostly stolen-and-laundered, but with full real paperwork. Three vehicles on offer for the trip:

1. **The Cargo Van.** Pre-Krash diesel, manual fallbacks (no remote-hijack surface), reinforced cabin, smuggler compartments in the floor for the droneware coolers, firing slits cut into the rear doors. Slow but durable. *This is non-negotiable — they need cargo space for the Ricochet and the goods.* SP 15, HP 50, Speed 5.
2. **A Dirtbike for Mats.** Per his lifepath, Mats has dirtbike experience. Kojo has a clean **Roadbike** ready (Cardinal Industries-style off-road model). Fast, agile, can flank in highway combat, can scout ahead, can leave a fight when the fight gets stupid. Speed 8, HP 25, SP 0. This dramatically changes road-combat dynamics — Mats becomes a mobile flanker rather than rear gunner.
Strongly recommended.
3. **Optional Third Vehicle.** Kojo can lease them a sleek sedan or a second pickup. The argument for a sedan: arriving at Tijuana buyer meetings in a corpo-grade vehicle is a status signal — Fredrik's Fixer instincts will love it. The argument for a pickup: redundancy and cargo. The argument against either: two vehicles is enough; three splits their fire. **GM recommendation: take the sedan only if the players want it. Two-vehicle convoy (van + bike) is the cleaner table experience.**

Kojo's note on the bike: *"It's clean. Papers are real, plate is real, the engine has no remote anything. Don't crash it, but if you have to crash it, crash it at someone."*

Pricing: Van comes free with the brokerage deal (Kojo is invested). Bike is 12,000 eb. Optional sedan is 25,000 eb. Players are good for it.

Stop 3: Final Prep

Players choose their final loadout adjustments. Some likely additions:

- **Ammo and weapons restock:** All players to full ammo. Mats picks up a melee weapon upgrade if he didn't already (a real combat knife: 1,500 eb; a Cyber-katana: 5,000 eb — *good for ring fights and for the inevitable next CQB*)
- **Comms gear:** Three encrypted radios with mesh networking — Digitz handles. Lets them stay in contact across vehicles without going through Agent infrastructure
- **First aid:** Two MedTech kits, two cyber-recovery autoinjectors (each restores 1d6 HP per use, 500 eb each)
- **Climate gear:** Mexico desert kit, water reserves, sun-rated gear. *Atmosphere only* — no mechanical effect, but a player who packed it can describe themselves as "the one who thought ahead"

GM Note for leveling: This is also where the **skill / role / humanity-recovery package** from the GM Quick Reference lands. Players announce their skill picks, the new Role Ability rank, and any other +1s while they're at Voss's recovering. Resolve all paperwork before they leave Night City.

Part 1: The Long Road

Kojo's final brief. Suki's basement, the night of departure. Kojo has done the rest of the work — buyer list, safehouse in Tijuana with Ofelia Castañeda, contact protocol for the Aldecaldos at the Snake's Nest waystation, helicopter charter for the auction transit.

He hands Fredrik a small leather notebook. *"My read on the buyers. Don't lose this. Don't read it in front of anyone. And don't show me a copy."* Inside: handwritten notes on each TJ contact, with stars next to who Kojo would trust if it were his neck.

He takes his cut up front: 15,000 eb. Cheap given what he's putting on the line.

The convoy: The cargo van (Fredrik driving, Digitz shotgun, Mats recovering from chrome install in the back through Day 1) and Mats's roadbike (parked in the van's cargo bay for the highway transit, ridden once they hit Free Fire Zone where flanking becomes useful). Optional sedan if they bought one — running ahead as a scout.

The route: Old I-5 south through what used to be San Diego County. The highway is technically intact — the off-ramps are not. Most of it is Free Fire Zone now, a 200-km stretch where the Aldecaldos and Snake Nation run informal toll waystations and *everyone else* is hostile.

GM Note: This part should run fast. 15-20 minutes max. The point is establishing the road, the mood, and getting them into the first combat.

The Highway Ambush (Don Bicho's Crew)

Late afternoon. Long shadows across the cracked highway. Mats spots it first — a tipped-over truck across both lanes about 800m ahead, smoke rising lazily. AWARENESS DV 13: it's staged. The smoke is wrong, too clean, and there are no skid marks.

Behind them, two converted technicals pull onto the highway from a frontage road — light pickups with autocannons welded to the beds and chain-skirt armor on the doors. A third vehicle, a heavy tow-rig with a ram bumper, accelerates from a side road on the right.

This is **Don Bicho's** crew. He hits convoys that bypass the Aldecaldos toll. He doesn't bother negotiating — he assumes you couldn't afford it, which means he'll just take what you have and roll on.

Vehicle Combat (Cyberpunk RED Chase Rules):

Run as a chase scene with three pursuers. Goal: lose them or reach the **Snake's Nest** turnoff ~15 km south, where Aldecaldos guns will deter pursuit.

VEHICLE	TYPE	STATS	NOTES
Players' Van	Cargo van, reinforced	Speed 5, SP 15, HP 50	Slow, durable. Fredrik drives, Digitz shotgun
Mats's Roadbike	Dirtbike	Speed 8, HP 25, SP 0	Mats can deploy from the van's rear ramp once contact starts. Off-road capable — can leave the highway
Optional Sedan	Sleek sedan	Speed 7, HP 30, SP 11	Only if they bought it. Lighter, faster, less durable than the van
Don Bicho's Tow-Rig	Heavy ram vehicle	Speed 6, SP 18, HP 60, ram 4d6	Driven by Don Bicho. Wants to pit the van off the road
Technical #1 / #2	Light pickup with autocannon	Speed 7, SP 11, HP 35	Crew of 3 each. Gunner does 5d6, ROF 1. Outrun-fast but glass

Mats on the bike: Major tactical wrinkle. Mats can flank the technicals (their autocannons are mounted, slow to traverse), draw the tow-rig's attention away from the van, or scout ahead for the Aldecaldos sniper position. His Pop-up VHP cyberarm and bike mobility together make him a serious threat to the lightly-armored technicals. This is the first encounter where the bike *changes* the fight rather than just being scenery.

Don Bicho: SP 18 (chrome plating), HP 50, Heavy SMG 4d6, Cyberarm with extending mantis blades 3d6 melee. If pulled into a fight on foot, he's *delighted*. He's a sadist.

Encounter beats: - Round 1: Technicals open up at range. Driver check DV 13 to weave; failure means the gunner gets a clean shot - Round 2: Mats (or whoever is back-doors) can return fire from the cargo van. The van has firing slits cut into the rear doors — Kojo prepared for this - Round 3: Don Bicho closes for the pit maneuver. Counter-driving check DV 15, or take a 4d6 ram hit and a difficult-terrain shake - Round 4-5: They should be closing on the Snake's Nest turnoff. As they crest a rise, two Aldecaldos snipers on a billboard ahead light up the technicals — first sniper round drops a gunner. Don Bicho pulls off. *"Until next time, gringos!"*

If the players want to stand and fight: Fine, but it's costly. Don Bicho will retreat once two of his three vehicles are critical. He doesn't die here — he becomes a recurring road threat for future returns south.

GM Note: The Aldecaldos extraction at the end is the *point* of this combat. Players learn (without being told): the Aldecaldos run this stretch, they noticed your trouble, they decided to help, and you now owe them an introduction. Don't lecture them on it — let the rescue do the talking.

Combat goal: Make vehicle combat feel different from everything in Adv 1–2. Fast, loud, mostly outside the van, with the urge to engage from cover. Mats can use Autofire here, which his sheet supports.

Part 2: The Snake's Nest (Aldecaldos Waystation)

A converted gas station and motel complex on the old I-5 corridor, ringed by junker trucks turned into walls. Smoke from grilling food. Children running. A working stage where someone is tuning an electric guitar. This place is *alive* in a way Night City rarely feels.

Arrival. The Aldecaldos receive them at the gate. The team of snipers that drove off Don Bicho is sitting on a roof, waving lazily. The players' van is escorted in. An old woman in welding goggles brings them water without being asked.

Meeting Mateo Cruz.

Mateo is the waystation elder. Mid-60s, snake tattoos up both arms, half-burned face, eyes that miss nothing. He receives them in a converted office with a wood stove and a chess set he's been playing against himself for ten years.

"You're carrying something hot. I don't need to know what. Kojo said you'd come, and Kojo doesn't lie to me. So we have business."

The favor he wants:

Don Bicho's crew has been growing. They hit the Snake's Nest three weeks ago — light probing attack, lost two raiders, retreated. Mateo's people repulsed it. But Bicho has been recruiting and he'll be back, harder, and probably tonight — because *he just lost face to your van*.

"You brought him here. You stay until he tries again. You help us put him down. Then I give you a clean passage south, an introduction at the border, and a letter to my cousin Esmé in Nueva Costa. That gets you in front of the right Nomad table."

The Players' Choice: - Accept: Aldecaldos goodwill, safe passage, an introduction to Tía Esmé (one of the four buyers) - Decline: They leave tonight, but the Aldecaldos won't extend hospitality on the way back, and Tía Esmé won't take their meeting cold

PERSUASION / CONVERSATION: Fredrik can negotiate additional terms (DV 15: Aldecaldos contribute fighters to the camp defense Fredrik can position; DV 17: they throw in fuel and a swap vehicle).

The Camp Defense (Combat — Ricochet's Big Day)

Sundown. The camp is settling for night. Mateo's scouts report movement on the I-5 corridor — Don Bicho's force is heavier this time. Three technicals, the ram-rig, and a stolen *mil-spec MRAP* (where the hell did he get one). 18-22 raiders total.

The setup: - The camp has two natural approaches: north along the highway (open ground for ~400m), south through a wash that gives cover - The players are the *anchor* of the defense. Mateo's people fight, but the players are positioned at the most likely breach point — the north gate - This is the **Ricochet's day in the sun**. Players have time to deploy it (10 min, TECH DV 13). The two-radar arc covers the entire north approach. The turret has a clean firing line to ~250m

Deployment options: 1. Standard placement covering the north approach — punishes the technicals as they come down the highway 2. Repositioned to cover the south wash — saves the camp from a flanking attack but leaves the north gate to the players directly 3. Split: one radar covering each approach (the -4 penalty applies, but coverage doubles)

The Fight:

WAVE	COMPOSITION	NOTES
1 (round 1-2)	3 technicals advancing up the highway, autocannon suppression	Ricochet's ideal target. Two bursts and at least one technical is wrecked
2 (round 3-4)	MRAP rolls forward as cover for 8 raiders dismounting	The MRAP is SP 25, HP 80. Ricochet damage rolls poorly here — needs concentrated PC fire or improvisation. Mats with the assault rifle and aimed shots can hurt the dismounts
3 (round 5-6)	Don Bicho personally leads 4 melee specialists through the south wash	Aldecaldos and players need to flex to the south. Genuine CQB risk. This is where someone takes serious damage
4 (round 7+, if still going)	Bicho's remaining force breaks. He himself fights to escape, takes 2 PCs with him if he can, runs in a hover-cycle stashed in the wash	He survives unless players really commit. Future antagonist

Raider stats (rank-and-file): SP 7, HP 30, Heavy Pistol 3d6 or SMG 2d6. **Melee specialists:** SP 11, HP 40, Cyberlimb 3d6 or Combat Knife with Reflexes upgrade. **Don Bicho:** SP 18, HP 50, Heavy SMG 4d6, mantis-blade cyberarm 3d6, Sandevistan (one-time use, +3 init when activated).

Tactical wrinkles: - Mateo's people are competent but outnumbered. Without the players, the south wash collapses in round 4 - A Aldecaldos kid — maybe 12 years old — runs ammunition to the players during the fight. Optional roleplay beat: do they let her? Tell her to get back? She's brave and she's been doing this since she was eight. Her name is **Cati** - After the fight: the camp survives, and Reyna Solano's *cousin* is among the wounded Aldecaldos. This plants a soft connection for Part 5 — Reyna will recognize the players' name when they meet at the bout

GM Note: This combat should *feel* like a defense. Players choosing positioning matters. The Ricochet rewards forethought. Don't pull punches — someone should take Seriously Wounded damage here. The Aldecaldos celebration that night is the reward.

Aftermath: Camp survives. Mateo embraces each of them in turn. Cati gives Mats a small steel pendant her mother made. Mateo provides: - Letter of introduction to **Tía Esmé Aldecaldo** in Nueva Costa - A token for **Comandante Castillo** at the border (a Aldecaldos snake-mark coin — Castillo takes the coin, *he doesn't take cash from you*) - Fuel, a swap of supplies, basic mechanical repair on the van - The waystation's brand-of-respect: a small snake tattoo, offered free, on a place of their choosing. **GM Note:** If any player takes it, mark a positive faction standing they can call on once per future adventure

Part 3: La Frontera (The Border)

The old US-Mexico border crossing south of San Ysidro. The Federal infrastructure is rusted out. **Comandante Castillo** runs the checkpoint with about 30 men and a battery of salvaged anti-air. He's not technically a warlord — he was an actual Federal officer who never got the order to abandon his post, so he just kept *operating it*. Now he charges crossing fees.

Arrival.

A line of trucks, motorcycles, and one impossibly old yellow taxi. Castillo's men work the line professionally — a kind of feudal bureaucracy. Forms, fees, vehicle search. The whole operation feels closer to a TSA checkpoint than to a smuggler crossing.

The team is two from the front when a **Trauma Team escort van** comes through the *opposite* lane, heading north. It's traveling with a black armored sedan. AWARENESS DV 15 in passing: through the rear window of the sedan, a figure in profile — older, glasses, the kind of bone structure that the players spent some time staring at in old Arasaka R&D headshots. **The Mole.**

The convoy is past in five seconds. Trauma Team protocol is private and unanswerable; the players can't follow, can't intercept, can't even confirm. But they know what they saw.

"They got out."

GM Note: Do not play this as a plot turn. It's an Easter egg — a silent confirmation for the players that the Mole is alive and has exfiltrated north. They don't get a conversation, they don't get a thank-you, they don't get any of it. If they ask anyone about Trauma Team convoys passing the border, the answer is *"Trauma Team takes a lot of people across that line, friend. They don't tell us who."* Let it be a quiet emotional beat.

At the Window.

The team reaches Castillo's clerk. Standard interrogation. Vehicle search incoming.

Resolution options:

1. **Mateo's coin.** Hand the snake-mark coin to the clerk. The clerk stops what he's doing. *"One moment, please."* He fetches Castillo personally. Castillo is small, weathered, military-formal. He accepts the coin, *salutes the team* (he respects Mateo), waves them through. Vehicle search canceled. *"Welcome to Mexico, señores. Don't make me a liar for letting you in."*

2. **Bribe.** 5,000 eb gets them through with a perfunctory search. PERSUASION DV 13 to keep the search shallow. Failure: search uncovers the droneware coolers, which initiates a separate negotiation (Castillo asks 50,000 eb to let it pass, and *will* fight if refused).

3. **Bluff their way through.** Forged paperwork, corpo cover. PERSUASION DV 17, with -2 if anyone in the party still has obvious chrome-merc presentation. Failure: vehicle search, see #2.

4. **Force.** Suicide. Castillo's anti-air takes the van apart at 200m on the south side. *Don't do this.*

GM Note: Most groups will use the coin. If they didn't earn the coin (skipped Part 2's defense) they have to bribe or bluff. That's the design.

Part 4: Tijuana

Crossing in. Mexico opens up. The first 20 minutes south of the border feels like a dream sequence — old neon storefronts powered by diesel generators, marigold garlands strung between balconies, three different radio stations bleeding into the van’s speakers, a sky the color of antiseptic. It is not Night City. Night City is *behind*.

Day of the Dead is in three days. The auction is timed for it deliberately — buyers travel for the festival, money moves through the city, and corp security focuses on the wealthier zones. The whole city is in pre-festival mode. Cyber-lucha posters paper every wall. Pan de muerto in every bakery window. A giant inflatable Catrina above the avenida.

The safehouse. Ofelia “Ofi” Castañeda runs a flower shop in Zona Norte with two reinforced apartments above it. The shop is real — she sells real flowers, mostly to real florists, and the cash is laundering cover. The apartments above are her safe-letting business for visiting fixers.

Ofi. Late 30s, dark hair pulled back, perpetual cigarette, doesn’t smile until she decides you’ve earned one. Her Spanish is fluid Tijuanaense and her English is rapid-fire and clinical. She runs the door on her terms.

“Kojo says I should treat you like family. I’m going to do something close to that. The apartment is yours through the auction. The shop downstairs is mine. If you steal a single carnation I will shoot you in the femoral. Bienvenidos.”

The buyer landscape briefing.

Ofi sits the players down with a bottle of mezcal and a hand-drawn diagram. She walks them through the four buyers Kojo identified, plus a fifth she’s adding herself:

BUYER	REPRESENTS	PAYS IN	OFI'S READ
Doña Esperanza Vargas	Los Curanderos (ripperdoc cartel)	Cash + permanent clinic favor	Reliable. Religious. Means what she says. <i>Will not</i> meet you cold — must earn it through Tuesday's lucha card
Mr. Vega	Militech cutout (almost certainly)	Cash, a lot of it	Smooth. Educated. Will know your file. Selling here puts you on Militech's roster permanently — they call, you answer
Tía Esmé Aldecaldo	The Aldecaldos Nomad family	Modest cash + deep alliance + a Nomad family bond	Best long-term play. Won't outbid Vega on cash. Will outbid him on <i>what it gets you for the rest of your life</i> . Needs Mateo's letter
Iku Tanaka	Pacific Rim medical conglomerate (claims)	Top dollar, clean transfer	Slick. <i>Too clean</i> . Ofi doesn't trust him. Won't say why. Won't tell you not to take the meet
The Auction itself	Open bidding floor at Nueva Costa	Whatever the room pays	Maximum cash if it goes well, total exposure if it goes badly. Recommended only with a sponsor in the room

She lays out the **3-day plan**: - **Day D-2 (Tuesday)**: La Lucha Cromada. Curanderos gate. *"Win or lose, fight well. The Doña watches the card herself"* - **Day D-1 (Wednesday)**: Buyer meetings around the city. Each on the buyer's terms - **Day D-0 (Thursday)**: Helicopter from the seawall at sundown. Auction on Nueva Costa, sundown to midnight

Player initiative: They can deviate. They can scout the auction venue early. They can try to meet Doña Esperanza without the lucha (won't work cold — but Fredrik can establish that he tried). They can spend the morning of Tuesday at the Día de los Muertos parade to soak in the local flavor. The schedule is theirs.

GM Note: Lean into atmosphere here. Tijuana should feel as physically different from Night City as you can make it — sun, dust, food smells, color, languages braided together, infrastructure that is *older and more human-scale*. Spend time on it. The players will reward it.

Part 5: La Lucha Cromada

Tuesday night. La Plaza Hueso. A converted bullring in central Tijuana. Capacity 4,000, sold out, painted sugar skulls on every column, a brass band that doubles as the entry music for the fighters. Día de los Muertos is two nights away and the whole crowd is already wearing face paint.

Doña Esperanza has reserved a private box on the second tier. She's wearing black, drinking from a small ceramic cup, and watching the card with the focused stillness of someone evaluating cattle.

The Card. Three matches before the main event. Players can mingle, place bets, listen. STREETWISE/PERSUASION rolls reveal: Reyna Solano "La Viuda" is the biggest star on this card. She wants out of the circuit but the syndicate has her contract. She fights *clean*. Her partners El Padre and El Hijo are veterans, professional, not psychopaths.

The Match. Players are slotted as the challenger team in the final card. 3-on-3 tag-team, two falls out of three, non-lethal cyberware ruleset (no firearms, no monoblade weapons, no lethal-effect cyberware).

Crowd payoff: Reyna recognizes Mats and Fredrik when they enter — "*Aldecaldos!*" she shouts to her cornermen, having heard about the camp defense from her cousin. She raises a fist to them across the ring. The crowd reads it as a salute between champions. **Faction goodwill, made physical.**

Mat: Mats's spotlight. Run this combat with Mats as the on-table lead. Fredrik and Digitz can tag in for shorter sequences, but Mats's Combat Awareness +5 DMG, his Melee Weapon 6, his cyberarm slam (use as Big Knuckles 3d6 for in-ring purposes since the Pop-up pistol is banned) — all of this is built for this scene.

Round structure (run as 3 narrative rounds, ~3 exchanges each):

ROUND	ACTION	STAKES
1	Establishment. Posturing, crowd work, first exchanges. Opponents test stats. Aim for a back-and-forth	Crowd warming up
2	The mid-fight wrinkle. La Viuda's Sandevistan activates for a turn — gives her +3 init and the chance to land a clean shot. Crowd gasps. She <i>almost</i> uses the monoblade fan — visibly pulls the strike at the last second. The ref doesn't see it. El Padre slams Mats for a near-pin — escape with REF check DV 15 or take the first fall	Match tied 1-1 by end
3	The closer. Both teams desperate. El Hijo's flashpaste cyberware misfires (or is set off intentionally — GM choice) creating a 1-round visibility drop and chaos. Whoever uses the chaos best wins. Either team can take the second fall	Match ends here

Stats (use as guidance, simplified):

FIGHTER	HP	SP	ATTACK	KEY TRAIT
El Padre	60	14	Cyberarm slam 4d6, grapple specialist	Slow, strong. Tank. Hard to escape grapple (DV 15)
La Viuda (Reyna)	35	9	Cyberarm 3d6, Sandevistan 1x	Glass cannon. Fast. Won't actually go lethal
El Hijo del Diablo	40	11	Cyber-foot kicks 3d6, flashpaste 2d6 fire (3m cone, once per match)	Theatrical. Tries to play to the crowd

Damage handling: All damage is “tracked” but doesn’t actually reduce HP below 1 — the ref calls submissions and pins on cumulative damage milestones. Run as a narrative-mechanical hybrid; don’t be afraid to fudge for drama. Players cannot die in this match. They can lose face, take chrome scuffs, and earn the crowd’s respect or its boos.

Outcome: - **Win:** Crowd erupts. Doña Esperanza tips her ceramic cup toward them. A handler arrives within 5 minutes: *“La Doña verá a ustedes mañana. Sus términos.”* Vega ALSO approaches that night (see below) - **Lose:** Crowd respects them anyway if they fought clean. Doña Esperanza watches them out — judgmental but not dismissive. Handler arrives with: *“La Doña dice que tienen valor. Mañana a las tres.”* Curanderos meet still happens, but Doña Esperanza will price them as B-list. Vega still approaches

Mr. Vega’s approach. After the bout, in the cooldown corridor under the stands. A man in a linen suit, no visible chrome, no obvious security but *something is wrong with the air around him*. He extends a card. *“Mr. Vega. I represent interested parties from the north. I was given a recommendation, and I confirmed it tonight. May we speak tomorrow?”* Hands them a coordinates card for a rooftop bar. *“Five o’clock. Just the three of you. Pay for your own drinks; I will not insult you with hospitality.”* Then he is gone.

Part 6: The Buyer Tour

Wednesday. Players run their meetings.

This part is roleplay-heavy. Each meeting is a short scene (~15-25 min of play). Order is up to the players. Each buyer will subtly try to learn what the other buyers offered — Fredrik will pick up on this immediately (Human Perception). Each one offers their best terms, and each will *raise* their terms once they realize they're in a competitive bidding situation.

Meet 1: Doña Esperanza Vargas (Curanderos)

Location: Iglesia de la Santa Trinidad, a deconsecrated church in Colonia Libertad. Used as the Curanderos' main clinic. Surgical theater behind the altar. Stained glass intact.

She receives them in the rectory. The smell is incense and isopropyl alcohol. She makes them coffee herself.

“Two units. One for me. The other you sell elsewhere. I do not need to be a monopolist — I need to be the buyer your community remembers fondly. I pay 80,000 eb for one unit, and you have permanent surgical privileges at any Curanderos clinic, for the three of you, for life. This is a forever offer.”

Read: Genuine. She means it. The “permanent clinic” terms are real and traceable through Curanderos's reputation. This is the *safest* buyer.

Negotiation possibilities (Fredrik): - DV 13: +10,000 eb on the cash component - DV 15: She'll add a Curanderos-installed piece of mid-grade cyberware (~5k eb value) for each PC - DV 17: She'll also pay protection if Arasaka comes asking — Curanderos has a small but vicious cyber-medical militia

Meet 2: Tía Esmé Aldecaldos (Aldecaldos)

Location: Cantina La Serpiente, in a Nomad-owned compound on the eastern edge of TJ. Players need Mateo's letter to get past the door. Inside: bandana-and-leather, kids running between tables, a band playing norteño-electric.

Tía Esmé is in her 50s, lean, gray-streaked braid, snake-mark coin on a chain. She receives them at a corner table with two bowls of birria.

“Mateo says you defended his people. That is rare. Most of the time a stranger ‘defends our people’ to mean they fired their weapon in our direction and called it brotherhood. You actually fought. That changes the conversation.”

“The Aldecaldos want the droneware. We want it because every year more of us die to corps who think we are road kill. We want a weapon that puts the fear on the other side of the equation. We cannot pay what Militech pays. We can pay what alliance pays.”

Her offer: - 35,000 eb in cash - Permanent Aldecaldos family bond for the three of them — meaning every Aldecaldos waystation, on every road in the Americas, becomes a place where they sleep safe, eat free, and can call for backup - A position with the family if any of them ever wants it (relevant for long-term character arcs) - **One condition:** they don’t sell the second unit to anyone in the corporate sphere, and they don’t tell *anyone* it was the Aldecaldos who bought it

Read: True. The family bond is the kind of thing that pays out for the rest of their lives. The cash is lousy by comparison to Vega’s offer. The bond is priceless.

Negotiation: Tía Esmé won’t raise the cash. She’ll raise the bond’s depth if Fredrik impresses her (DV 15: a personal stake from her own clan; DV 17: a kuvasz dog-sized cyber-mastiff trained as a guardian, given to whichever PC she likes most)

Meet 3: Mr. Vega (Militech cutout)

Location: Rooftop bar of the Hotel Camino del Mar. Mediterranean cocktails. View of the Pacific. Vega is on time. He’s alone, or at least appears alone (Mats’s AWARENESS DV 15: there is a sniper team across the boulevard. They are not for the players. They are for Vega’s safety. Standard practice).

“I represent parties for whom your two units are of substantial interest. We pay 150,000 eb for both. Wire transfer through any laundry of your choosing. We do not require a sponsor’s mark or an alliance. We do not require gratitude. We do require that the units transfer cleanly and that you and we never have this conversation again.”

The catch: He never says “Militech,” but his speech, his protection detail, his briefcase, the man’s posture all say it. Selling here means: - They become *assets* on Militech’s books — not exactly enemies, but people Militech can call on - They never appear on Militech’s payroll, but they will be expected to receive Militech calls in the future - If Arasaka ever comes back at them, Militech *might* help. Or might not. *“Discretion serves both parties.”*

Negotiation: - DV 15: +20,000 eb - DV 17: A non-extradition guarantee — if Arasaka issues a bounty, Militech-aligned territories will not honor it - DV 19: Vega will go to 250,000 total but at this point he’s irritated and the relationship sours. Fredrik will *feel* the chill

Meet 4: Iku Tanaka (the trap)

Location: A private dining room at a sushi place near the seawall. White tablecloths. Quiet. Tanaka is alone. Mid-40s, Japanese, perfect posture, a single subtle neural-link port behind his ear.

“I represent a Pacific Rim medical foundation. We have a particular interest in advanced neural-bridging cyberware. We are willing to pay 180,000 eb for both units, payable in immediate cash on transfer at the auction. We would prefer a private transaction; we will accept the auction venue if you require it.”

Read on Tanaka — multiple Human Perception checks build a picture: - DV 13: He is extremely good at small talk. He has memorized details about each player from somewhere - DV 15: His “Pacific Rim medical foundation” doesn’t show up in any of the searches Digitz can run during dinner. Nothing. *Nothing at all.* A real entity would have some footprint - DV 17: His Japanese is too good to be a Pacific Rim general dialect — it’s *Tokyo metropolitan, Arasaka corporate dialect*. This is a tell only Mats might catch, given his Japanese-1 background skill, or only if Fredrik has been listening for it - DV 19: There is a very small Arasaka logo embossed inside the band of his watch. Visible only when he tilts his wrist to drink. Lucky catch only

He is Arasaka counterintelligence. He is not here to buy. He is here to *learn the meet location, learn who else is bidding, and arrange a Section-9 takedown at the auction venue.*

If players signal they’re onto him: Tanaka is polite, finishes dinner, leaves the bill. Inside the next two hours, the safehouse robbery (below) becomes much more aggressive.

If players don’t catch him: He walks away pleased. The auction-night attack still happens, but the players are unprepared for it.

The Safehouse Robbery (Combat — Urban CQB)

Wednesday night, 03:00. The team is sleeping or planning. Suddenly Ofelia’s perimeter sensors (she has them — she has *a lot* of them) trigger.

Six masked operators are coming over the flower-shop roof and through the back gate simultaneously. **They are not Tanaka’s people.** They are local talent — Tijuana-grade muscle hired by one of the *losing* buyers (or Tanaka, if the players tipped him off too hard) to *steal the droneware before the auction.*

This combat is urban CQB: - Tight quarters — apartment hallway, stairwell, flower shop floor - Ofelia fights alongside the players (SP 11, HP 35, Heavy Pistol 3d6, knows the building like her own hand) - The Ricochet is in the van in the alley. **Can be deployed but only as a “fire from cover” position** — players need to fight their way *to* it to bring it online (TECH DV 13 + 5 min)

Opposition:

TYPE	SP	HP	WEAPON	NOTES
Robber (x4)	11	35	SMG 2d6, flashbang	Pros, not aces. Will not push if losing
Crew Boss	13	40	Heavy SMG 4d6	The mind. Calls retreat at 2 casualties
Their Netrunner	9	25	Light Pistol 1d6	Stays in a van outside, tries to scramble Ofelia's cameras. Digitz can engage him from inside — short combat net run, DV 15 Interface, takes 1d6 net damage on failure

Resolution: - Robbers driven off: standard outcome. They lose 2-3, retreat with wounded. Ofelia is *furious*. Players can interrogate any captured for who hired them — leads to a buyer (GM choice: Tanaka if players didn't read him, or one of the losing buyers as a sour-grapes play) - Players overwhelm: rare, but possible. All hostiles down. Police presence in 20 min. They need to be gone before then

GM Note: This is a fast combat. 30-40 minutes. The point is variety (urban CQB after the lucha and after the road fights) and a reminder that the auction is not going to be quiet.

Part 7: Costa Muerta (The Auction)

Thursday at sundown. The seawall helipad. A converted Sea King helicopter waits for the team. Ofelia is the door agent. Each buyer's representatives board at the same time — Doña Esperanza in person with a single bodyguard, a Militech junior staffer on Vega's behalf (Vega himself stays in TJ — *"I'll be reachable"*), Tía Esmé with two armed Aldecaldos cousins, Iku Tanaka alone, and a half-dozen unknown other buyers from across the Pacific Rim and Latin America.

Pre-flight: Ofelia hands the players a hardcase. *"Two units. Sealed by me, witnessed by Doña Esperanza when she signed in. Don't lose this case. Don't open it before the auction. And god help you if you spill anything wet on it."*

The flight: 35 minutes, west into the Pacific. Sundown over the ocean. The rigs come up like a constellation rising from below — strings of light on a dozen platforms anchored together with gangways and cable.

Nueva Costa.

Picture a daisy-chain of converted Pemex platforms, lashed together with bridges, ramps, and rope, and connected by a central platform that hosts the **Costa Muerta auction floor**. Each rig is a different fiefdom: a ripperdoc rig, a data-broker rig, a market rig, a residential rig for the workers, and the central platform that hosts the *Salón de la Casa Muerta* — the auction hall, an elegant converted helicopter hangar lined with skulls and marigolds for the Día festival.

The Hosts. Three syndicates run Nueva Costa jointly — a Curanderos-allied ripperdoc cartel, a data-broker collective called **La Red**, and an Aldecaldos-adjacent Nomad maritime family known as **Los Marinos**. None of the three syndicates are *armed enough* to dominate the others, which is why everyone tolerates the arrangement. This will become important.

House rules: - All firearms checked at the central platform armory on arrival. PCs get one concealed sidearm each (house norm; can't enforce *zero* weapons among professional buyers) - The Ricochet stays on the helicopter. *Cannot* be brought to the auction floor - Internal disputes are handled by **the Pacers** — a small contingent of armored peacekeepers from each syndicate, ~12 total, who patrol the central platform. They don't break up bidding disputes. They break up shootings - Auction lots are presented one at a time. Bidding is open. The seller (the players) sit in a sponsor box. The high bidder takes the lot at end-of-bidding. Failed lots return to the seller

Auction Mechanics.

There are six lots tonight. The drone units are **Lot 4 and Lot 5** — back-to-back, by design. Other lots include: a militec-grade dataset, a Petrochem core sample (chemistry secret), some other dark-end items. None of those are the players' problem.

Pre-bid setup: Before Lot 4, the auctioneer (a woman in a black-and-gold mask, mic'd to the room) introduces the lot. The room sees what they're buying. Each buyer can examine the unit briefly through a glass case. Doña Esperanza nods slightly. Tía Esmé's bodyguard whispers something to her. Vega's staffer is taking notes on a paper pad. **Tanaka is not there.**

That is the first red flag.

The Attack.

Round 1. Mid-bidding on Lot 4. The lights in the Salón flicker once. Then twice. The auctioneer pauses. Then the lights go out completely.

Emergency lighting kicks in — dim red. The room is on its feet. Someone is shouting. A muffled *bang* outside.

What's happening: A small Arasaka Section-9 team — six operators in light EVA-style suits — has just boarded the residential rig from a stealth submersible. They've cut the auction floor's external comms and they're pushing toward the Salón to take both drone units and exfiltrate. Tanaka is on the sub coordinating. He never came to the auction because he was always going to seize the lots, not bid on them.

Round 2-3. First gunfire from outside. The Pacers respond — three of them down in the first volley. The Section-9 team is *good*. The Salón doors are reinforced but not magic.

Player options:

1. **Defend the Salón.** Hold the auction floor. The other buyers will fight alongside them if asked properly — Doña Esperanza has her bodyguard, Tía Esmé's cousins, Vega's staffer with a hidden Sandevistan-Heavy Pistol combo. All in, the players have +4 allies in the room. The Section-9 team is 6 strong and very, very good.
2. **Counter-board the submersible.** A wild play — fight to one of the docking points, take the submersible, capture Tanaka. High risk, high reward. Tanaka is alive at the end if so.
3. **Run with the case.** Take the drone units and bolt — out a service hatch, across the gangways to the helicopter rig. Section-9 will follow. Running fight across multiple platforms.

Section-9 Team:

TYPE	SP	HP	WEAPON	NOTES
Section-9 Operator (x5)	15	45	SMG 4d6, Smart Frag Grenades, Sandevistan	Coordinated. Professional. Will not freelance — every action serves the team mission
Section-9 Team Lead	17	55	Tech-rifle 5d6, full neural interface, micro-drone scout	Will sacrifice ops to grab the case
Iku Tanaka (on sub)	11	40	Heavy Pistol 3d6, Smart link	Only encountered if players counter-board. Surrenders immediately if cornered

The Salón Defense.

The Salón is an ideal *defensive* space — one main entry, two service entries, no windows. The challenge is that *the entire auction is inside*. Twenty buyers, ten staff, the auctioneer, the band. The Section-9 team will frag grenade through the doors if not deterred.

- **Doña Esperanza** is unflappable. She crosses herself, draws a chrome derringer, and posts up behind a column. *“Hijos, you defend my new property. I’ll pay the bonus.”*
- **Tía Esmé** is in her element. Calling tactical orders to her cousins. Locks eyes with Mats: *“Mátalos.”*
- **Vega’s staffer** flips a coin: doesn’t fight unless personally engaged, in which case he is *terrifying* (4d6 Heavy Pistol with smart link).
- **The Pacers** — the surviving 8 — set up the second perimeter at the service corridor. The players can coordinate with them: PERSUASION DV 13 to integrate. If integrated, the Pacers add 3d6 Heavy Pistol fire per round at the operators’ approach.

Wave structure: - Round 1: Lights out, frag at the main door (Players + Pacers absorb. Door SP 15) - Round 2-3: Section-9 breaches main door. Two operators in. Players + Doña + Tía’s cousins respond. Aim for one Section-9 operator down by end of round 3 - Round 4-5: Section-9 tries the service corridor. Vega’s staffer reveals his Sandevistan and *delivers*. One more operator down - Round 6-7: The Team Lead leads a final push directly for the case. This is the most dangerous round — frag grenades into the bidder section, Sandevistan-enhanced charge. Aim for someone PC-adjacent to get hurt - Round 8+: If Section-9 has lost 4, they retreat. If they’ve lost the Team Lead, they retreat immediately. If the players are losing, *Doña Esperanza herself* takes a 6d6 shot to defend the case — she lives, but it’s a near thing. *She remembers who paid that debt.*

The Counter-board option.

Risky but possible. Players must fight to the residential rig dockpoint where the submersible is moored. ~3 minutes of platform-running and incidental fire. Once at the sub: the operators left a small guard (2 Section-9 + Tanaka).

If captured, Tanaka is a *gold mine* — but interrogating him is its own complication. Arasaka will pay anything to get him back. Other buyers (especially Tía Esmé and Doña Esperanza) will *want* him. Selling Tanaka becomes an additional auction lot the players control. Tía Esmé will pay handsomely. Doña Esperanza will pay more. Vega's staffer will go cold and *very interested*.

Run with the case option.

Fastest combat — about 4 rounds of running fight across gangways. Players make it to the helicopter rig, helicopter has been kept hot by the pilot (Ofelia's standing order: "*Engines running until everyone is back or everyone is dead*"). Liftoff. Section-9 hits one operator with a tagging dart that lets them track the chopper for ~30 minutes — but the chopper is fast and over open water. Player choice: dump the tag (find it, AWARENESS DV 15) or accept Tanaka knows where they landed.

Resolution of the Auction.

Assuming the players survive Section-9 and protect the case:

The auction *continues*. The room knows they just watched a corporate raid get repelled by the sellers of the lot in question. **This is worth bidding for.** A unit that the Arasaka Special Recovery Division wants this badly is a unit worth owning.

- **Doña Esperanza** opens at 100,000 eb
- **Tía Esmé** matches and offers her bond terms verbally
- **Vega's staffer** opens a phone line, gets approval, raises to 200,000 eb
- **A new buyer** — a quiet Petrochem rep who hadn't been on Ofelia's list — opens at 220,000 eb (GM may introduce this only if pacing wants a complication)

Final price floor: 220,000 eb for both units, or split between two buyers.

Players can split: sell one to Tía Esmé for the bond (taking a cash hit but gaining the alliance), and one to a cash buyer for top dollar. Or sell both as a lot. Their call.

Negotiation tools at this point: - PERSUASION DV 13: extract a "you owe me a favor" from whoever wins, on top of cash - PERSUASION DV 15: get a non-disclosure pact from the winners (they don't say who they bought from) - PERSUASION DV 17: get a Pacers stand-down on any future attempt to interfere with the players in Nueva Costa's reach (long-term — they can come back here safely)

Part 8: Aftermath

The helicopter lifts at midnight. The auction is closing, the auctioneer is taking a deep breath, the Pacers are cleaning up bodies on the gangways. Three Section-9 operators are alive and prisoner; the Team Lead is dead. Tanaka either escaped on the sub (most likely outcome) or is in a Pacers holding cell, depending on player choices.

Cash situation (typical outcome): - 100,000-250,000 eb in liquid funds, depending on negotiation - Curanderos clinic-for-life standing (if sold to Doña) - Aldecaldos family bond (if sold to Tía Esmé) - Militech roster entry (if sold to Vega) - One unit possibly retained — paranoid players sometimes keep one as leverage. *Strongly discourage this; the heat is over only because the units are gone*

Faction post-state: - **Doña Esperanza Vargas:** Strong ally if she got a unit. Owes one if she didn't bid high enough - **Tía Esmé Aldecaldos:** Strong ally if she got a unit. Strong ally regardless if Mateo's letter was used well. Aldecaldos family bond unlocked - **Mr. Vega / Militech:** Asset relationship if he got a unit. Cold neutrality if outbid - **Iku Tanaka / Arasaka:** Hostile, but smaller-scale than before. Section 9 took a serious operational loss; replacing this unit is expensive. They'll back off for a while - **Lazard:** Background only. Kojo passes word two days later: Lazard's internal audit was suspended; he was "reassigned" to an off-grid Arasaka facility in the Pacific Northwest. Translation: he's been deniably retired. The arc ends here — but his name has shape now, a *case file* shape in Arasaka's history - **The Mole:** The Trauma Team van on the border was confirmed. The Mole is alive and exfiltrated. They will not surface again for a long time - **Kojo:** Stronger than ever. He gets 10% of the take. He sends them a handwritten thank-you note via Ofelia. *He has never sent a handwritten anything in his life* - **Ofelia:** Friendly contact for any future Tijuana operations - **Reyna Solano "La Viuda":** Free agent. Won her bout. Sent the players a small painted cyber-mask as a gift. *"For when you next come south."*

The Day of the Dead.

The players spend the morning of Friday, November 2, on Nueva Costa as the syndicates clean up. By afternoon they're back in Tijuana. By evening they are walking through a massive Día de los Muertos parade in central TJ — face paint, marigolds, music, families remembering their dead.

Quiet beat. Mats stops at a small altar that has been set up in a corner of the plaza, looks at the photographs of strangers laid out in marigold petals. He has not put up an altar for anyone in a long time. He should think about that.

Fredrik buys flowers. Digitz, the GMPC, calls his mentor.

Setting up Adventure 4.

A few seeds for the next adventure, planted lightly:

1. **The Mole's exfil network.** Trauma Team across the border was paid by someone. The Mole had a sponsor. *Who?* This is the long-tail mystery
2. **Don Bicho on the road.** He survived. He has a grudge. He will be on the road north when they go back
3. **The Aldecaldos family bond.** If they took it, they're in for a Nomad-flavored future adventure — possibly a corp incursion on Nomad territory
4. **Militech's call** (if Vega bought). At some point, Vega's people will *ask* for something. That's a debt
5. **The Tanaka file.** If they captured him, what they extracted from him sets up a counterintelligence-adjacent arc. If he escaped, Section 9 has a new file open on the players
6. **Reyna Solano.** She wants out of the lucha circuit. The players are the only people who could plausibly help. She'll call

GM Note: Don't tip any of these. Let the players decide what they want to pull on. The strongest hook is whichever one they latch onto first.

EVENTS (RANDOM/TRIGGERED)

Phantom signal (placebo)

Trigger: Once, mid-adventure, GM discretion. Ideally at the buyer tour when stakes feel highest.

Effect: One player gets a flash-pop of static behind the eyes. A 1-second taste of the droneware signal — *but the droneware is gone*. It's a psychosomatic ghost. -1 to that player's next INT check. Pure unease. No mechanical threat.

This is for atmosphere. The players experienced an existential horror in Adv 2. The horror doesn't actually leave the body when the chrome does.

Calls from Ryla Vox

Trigger: Anytime between Parts 4-6.

Ryla calls Fredrik. She has been investigating Arasaka's level 17 internal collapse from her end. The official story is the players don't exist. The unofficial story (the Arasaka rumor mill) has them as *legendary*. Mercs in Night City are starting to drop their handles like a story. "*You okay? Tell me you're somewhere far away.*" Fredrik can share as little or as much as he wants. She mentions: she's writing the long-form story for News 54. It runs in three weeks. *Their names will not be in it.*

Day of the Dead overlay

Trigger: Tijuana scenes, Parts 4-6.

Every scene in TJ should have a Día de los Muertos beat. A street altar. A face-painted child. A mariachi band warming up for the festival. Marigold petals on a doorstep. *Atmosphere only*. Don't make it heavy.

SESSION PACING GUIDE

PHASE	TARGET TIME	NOTES
Part 0: The Send-Off	30-45 min	Cyberware install at Voss's, vehicles at Kojo's, loadout choices
Part 1: The Long Road	30-40 min	Establish road tone, run the highway ambush
Part 2: Snake's Nest	50-70 min	Roleplay + Ricochet's big defensive scene
Part 3: La Frontera	15-25 min	Quick negotiation, the Mole cameo
Part 4: Tijuana arrival	30-40 min	Atmosphere, Ofelia, buyer landscape
Part 5: La Lucha Cromada	40-60 min	Mats's spotlight, narrative combat
Part 6: Buyer Tour	80-110 min	Four meetings + safehouse robbery
Part 7: Costa Muerta	90-120 min	Auction + Section-9 climax
Part 8: Aftermath	25-40 min	Faction states, Día beat, hooks

Total estimated session time: 7-9 hours. This is bigger than #2. Consider splitting across two sessions: - **Session 3A:** Parts 0-4 (kit up, road south, arrival in Tijuana) - **Session 3B:** Parts 5-8 (Tijuana + auction)

If running as one session, trim Part 6 buyer meetings (combine two into a single “two-at-once” scene at a public location) and shorten Part 2 (skip the camp-defense as a full combat, run it abstracted with a single roll).

GM QUICK REFERENCE

Key DVs used in this adventure: - Easy: DV 11 (basic STREETWISE) - Standard: DV 13 (Aldecaldos negotiations, robbery defense) - Difficult: DV 15 (most buyer haggling, key AWARENESS reads on Tanaka) - Hard: DV 17 (vehicle-pit counter-driving, top-tier buyer raises, deep reads on Tanaka) - Very Hard: DV 19 (catching the Arasaka watch logo, max Vega negotiation)

Loot/Rewards (typical): - 100,000-250,000 eb cash (auction proceeds) - Faction relationships (Curanderos clinic privileges, Aldecaldos family bond, possible Militech asset status) - Captured Section-9 gear if applicable (mil-spec SMGs, EVA suits, smart frag grenades — ~30k eb resale value, but very heat-y) - Tanaka captured = political bargaining chip; never sell publicly, only trade - Mateo’s snake-mark tattoo (if accepted) — perennial Aldecaldos goodwill chip - A painted cyber-mask from Reyna Solano (sentimental, no stats)

Leveling guidance (between Adv 2 and Adv 3, or at the close of #3):

Run a flat leveling package per PC rather than counting IP for two infrequent sessions of damage and stress. Suggested package:

- **+1 to two skills of the player’s choice** (their pick — usually role-defining ones)
- **+1 Role Ability rank** if they’re under Rank 6 (Mats’s Combat Awareness, Fredrik’s Operator, Digitz’s Interface). If they’re at Rank 5 already, this is a non-trivial jump
- **Up to 5,000 eb of new cyberware or gear** (player’s pick, GM approval). Reasonable suggestions:
 - Mats: an Optical Camo cloak, a Smartlink, or a serious melee weapon upgrade (now that he’s done melee, he might want a real chrome blade)
 - Fredrik: a Voice Stress Analyzer upgrade, a Subdermal Armor (BODY+1), or a personal driver-AI for his vehicles
 - Digitz: a new program slot or two, a Cybermodem upgrade, or an Interface Plugs upgrade
- **+1 Humanity recovery** for any character below max — they had two months off, and Mats specifically had therapy time

Faction standing inheritance from this adventure: - Track each faction (Curanderos, Aldecaldos, Militech, Arasaka, Trauma Team, Tanaka/Section-9) on a -2 to +2 scale and update at session close. Future adventures should reference these